

If I were a mayor?

I. Introduction

Indianapolis, the vibrant heart of Indiana, stands at the crossroads of tradition and progress, where its rich history converges with a growing and diverse population. In 2021, the city's population reached 880,000, reflecting a tapestry of communities with a median age of 34.3 and a median household income of \$54,321. A closer look reveals a mosaic of ethnicities, with the largest groups being White (52.7%), Black or African American (28.5%), White (Hispanic) (5.04%), Asian (3.82%), and Two+ (3.7%) (DataUSA, n.d.).

As the mayor of Indianapolis, entrusted with the executive leadership of both the city and Marion County, I am compelled by a vision to make Indianapolis not just a city of residence but a welcoming haven for all its residents. This vision is rooted in the understanding that a city's true character is defined not only by its infrastructure and governance but by the sense of comfort and inclusivity it offers to each and every individual who calls it home.

Indiana's governance structure, mirroring the federal model, comprises three branches: executive, legislative, and judicial. The mayor, serving a renewable four-year term, is the head of the city's executive branch. My role extends beyond being the head of the city's government to also serve as the Marion County Executive, a unique responsibility stemming from UNIGOV, distinct from other counties in Indiana(gov,2023).

In this role, I navigate the intricacies of the city's governance, overseeing six departments and six city offices. My responsibilities range from enforcing ordinances and state laws to collaborating with the City-County Council and Marion County Commissioners on financial matters. Yet, amidst these responsibilities, my focus remains on a core objective: crafting a city that not only functions seamlessly but also radiates hospitality and warmth(office,2021).

This paper serves as a blueprint for my mayoral agenda, envisioning Indianapolis as a more welcoming and hospitable city. By scrutinizing key aspects such as inclusive street furniture, safety perceptions, and the integration of community arts, I aim to address the nuanced layers that contribute to the overall comfort and well-being of our residents. Together, let us embark on a journey to redefine Indianapolis, making it a city that embraces diversity, fosters connections, and radiates a genuine sense of belonging for everyone who calls it home.

II. Identifying the Characteristics of a Welcoming City

One of the first elements that makes a welcoming city in my opinion is the addition of street furniture and amenities. One may have the interesting question: what role does street furniture play, and what significance does it hold? Street furnishings, encompassing elements like benches and tables strategically placed in parks and squares, serve as not just functional amenities for resting, sitting, and dining but also as catalysts for social interactions. These environments, particularly crucial for the elderly, individuals with limited mobility, and parents with small children, extend beyond mere utility(Gupta,2021). Urban furniture, when thoughtfully chosen

and positioned, not only enhances the physical comfort of outdoor spaces but also contributes to the creation of a welcoming, comforting ambiance that beckons people to gather and socialize. The challenge lies not only in inviting individuals outdoors but in ensuring they feel embraced, at ease, and eager to engage with their surroundings.

Another key aspect in crafting a more comfortable city, aligning with street furniture and amenities, is the city's perceived safety and inclusivity. In a study conducted by J Urban Health it detailed the difference between urban comfort and individuals' perception of comfort in a city. The study reveals that feelings of safety when walking in one's neighborhood at night are intertwined with various factors. Notably, new residents, although not statistically significant, reported feeling somewhat safer (50.0%) compared to longer-term residents (56.0%). However, a statistically significant difference emerges when considering participants' birthplace, with those not born in the US expressing a higher likelihood of feeling unsafe (73.6%) compared to their US-born counterparts (52.4%). Furthermore, the research highlights a compelling correlation between feelings of unsafety and personal exposure to neighborhood violence. Individuals who had family or close friends affected by violence in their neighborhood reported a higher likelihood of feeling unsafe at night (68.1%) compared to those without such exposure (49.9%). Interestingly, no significant differences in perceptions of safety were observed based on gender and age (Guo, 2018). These findings emphasize the nuanced relationship between urban comfort, as influenced by amenities and street furniture, and the intricate interplay of safety perceptions and inclusivity within the city's fabric. In creating a truly comfortable city, it becomes imperative for planners and policymakers to address not only physical elements like street furniture but also the broader socio-cultural aspects that shape residents' perceptions of safety and belonging.

In a collaborative research initiative conducted by students from the Urban Planning and Transportation Group at Eindhoven University of Technology, the Department of Architecture at the University of Cambridge, and the School of Architecture at Hunan University, an in-depth exploration was undertaken to unravel the intricate dynamics influencing outdoor comfort. This study meticulously examined the relationships among individuals' enduring attitudes towards urban public spaces, their immediate environmental perceptions, and the comprehensive conceptualization of comfort, providing insights into diverse geographical contexts. People were asked questions about how they perceive the environment, how comfortable they feel, and their attitudes towards outdoor places. They used the formula below to represent how our feelings (latent variables) about things we have (y_i) and things we don't have (x_i) are related. It has two parts: the measurement model and the structural model. The measurement model measures how we feel about our things (y_i) and things we don't have (x_i). The equation helps us understand how our feelings (latent variables η_i and γ_i) affect what we say about our things (y_i and x_i). It also considers mistakes we might make in saying how we feel (ϵ_i and ζ_i). The structural model measured how our feelings about our things (η_i) are connected to feelings about things we don't have (γ_i). It has intercepts (starting points), coefficients (effects of one thing on another), and error terms (mistakes we might make in our feelings) (Peng, 2021).

$$(1) y_i = \alpha_y + \Lambda_y \eta_i + \epsilon_i$$

$$(2) x_i = \alpha_x + \Lambda_x \gamma_i + \zeta_i$$

There were a lot of interesting findings from this study that I think are quite useful that I will reference again my suggestions to make Indianapolis a welcoming and friendly city.

- People with higher incomes tend to have more positive attitudes towards outdoor places.
- Surprisingly, higher income negatively influences how comfortable people feel outdoors. This might mean wealthier people are less adaptable to outdoor environments.
- Older people tend to have more positive perceptions of the environment.
- Women and those with higher education tend to feel more comfortable outdoors.
- The outdoor temperature strongly affects how comfortable people feel.

The the findings that struck me the most in reading this scholarly article though were: "Older people tend to have more positive perceptions of the environment.", "Women and those with higher education tend to feel more comfortable outdoors.", "Surprisingly, higher income negatively influences how comfortable people feel outdoors" but it's juxtaposed with " People with higher incomes tend to have more positive attitudes towards outdoor places." To understand why I asked a couple of different questions that led me down a rabbit hole of different theories and explanations rooted in behavioral psychology, anthropology, and philosophy but I simplified the explanations to keep the main focus of improving Indianapolis the main focus.

Older individuals may have lived through various environmental changes, giving them a broader perspective. Evolutionarily, it makes sense for a community to value the experiences and wisdom of older members who have successfully navigated their environment. Cultural influences may play a significant role. Different societies may place varying importance on the experiences and wisdom of older individuals. Exploring cross-cultural differences in environmental perceptions could provide valuable insights. Research could also explore the interplay between personal experiences and evolutionary trends.

Societal protection of women and those with higher education might indeed stem from a historical need to safeguard vulnerable individuals and recognize and preserve the contributions of talented ones. Another thing to think about is how the intersectionality of factors influences comfort outdoors. For example, the experiences of women with higher education might differ from those with lower education levels. Exploring how multiple identity factors intersect can provide a more nuanced understanding. Further research could delve into societal structures and historical contexts to understand how protection mechanisms have evolved and how they

manifest in different cultures.

The last explanation that was initially confusing for me was the idea about higher income and how it affected not only their perception of comfortability but their attitudes towards outdoors as well. This seems paradoxical, but it might be due to various factors. Positive attitudes towards outdoor places may stem from a general appreciation, while feeling uncomfortable could be linked to concerns like personal safety, the pressure to maintain a certain image, or a heightened awareness of potential threats. Evolutionarily, success might attract envy or competition, leading to discomfort. Research could explore the psychological and evolutionary aspects of how success influences feelings outdoors.

Transitioning from the comprehensive examination of urban comfort dynamics, our focus now turns to a pivotal urban enhancement – the role of art in fostering a welcoming and hospitable city. Having explored the intricate relationships between enduring attitudes, immediate environmental perceptions, and the holistic conceptualization of comfort, we set the stage for an in-depth analysis of how the integration of art into the urban fabric could contribute significantly to cultivating warmth and hospitality within the city of Indianapolis. In an article titled “Building Communities in Tense Times: Fostering Connectedness Between Cultures and Generations through Community Arts” it talks about the benefits of art and how those foster a welcoming city. The study delves into three specific projects, illustrating how community arts can foster individual and collective pride, as well as a sense of community belonging. Three fundamental principles underpinning this achievement are explored: interactive processes, the transmission and hybridization of stories and images portraying adversity and resilience, and the access to a collective voice (Beauregard, 2019).

The study draws on Deborah Barndt's (2008) community arts approach, emphasizing four interactive processes. Collaboration stands out as central to every project, taking various forms such as parents–children, youths–elders, or participants–facilitators. The facilitators' role is crucial in establishing trust, fostering collaborations, and creating a safe relational space, contributing to the development of strong connections and community resilience. Participants engage in sharing verbal and non-verbal stories as a means of building bridges across social divides. The community arts activities become "contact zones," shaping relationships and transforming identities. Through shared artworks, performances, and stories, participants work on commonalities and address social divisions, utilizing collective creation as a platform for shared expression (Beauregard, 2019). The study suggests that if having a collective voice involves expressing collectively the texture of daily life, dreams, and emotions related to belonging and exclusion, then participants did indeed express their collective voice through various arts projects. In summary this article exemplifies how community arts projects can serve as powerful mechanisms for fostering connections, resilience, and shared expressions among

individuals from diverse backgrounds within a community.

III. Public Policy Proposals

To fortify the welcoming nature of Indianapolis, a strategic focus on inclusive street furniture is proposed. This involves the careful selection and placement of benches, tables, and other amenities in public spaces, with a special emphasis on catering to the needs of diverse demographics such as the elderly, individuals with limited mobility, and parents with young children. By prioritizing universally accessible and thoughtfully positioned urban furniture, the aim is to not only enhance the physical comfort of outdoor spaces but also to foster a sense of community and social interaction. Collaborative efforts with urban planners, architects, and community members can ensure that these public spaces are not only aesthetically pleasing but also genuinely accommodating to the needs and preferences of Indianapolis residents.

In response to the findings regarding safety perceptions in the study by J Urban Health, a comprehensive public policy proposal is recommended. Initiatives should be developed to address factors influencing feelings of safety at night, particularly for new residents and those not born in the US. Community engagement programs, neighborhood watch initiatives, and cultural integration projects could be implemented to enhance safety perceptions and promote inclusivity. Additionally, partnerships with local law enforcement and community organizations can play a crucial role in creating a safer and more inclusive environment. By addressing the complex interplay of safety perceptions, cultural backgrounds, and exposure to neighborhood violence, Indianapolis can actively work towards becoming a city where all residents feel secure and welcomed.

Building upon the insights from the article "Building Communities in Tense Times: Fostering Connectedness Between Cultures and Generations through Community Arts" by Caroline Beauregard the integration of community art projects emerges as a powerful tool to foster connections and a sense of belonging within Indianapolis. A proposed public policy involves establishing a dedicated fund for community arts initiatives that encourage collaboration across generations and cultures. Facilitators and artists would play a key role in creating safe spaces for expression, enabling individuals to share their stories and experiences. By embracing community arts as a means to address social divisions and create collective expressions, Indianapolis can cultivate a shared narrative that enhances community pride and unity.

To further the aim of creating a welcoming and friendly city, there is a need to invest in inclusive public spaces. This involves not only the physical design of spaces but also the programming of events and activities that cater to diverse interests and demographics. Public consultation processes can be initiated to gather input from the community on the types of spaces and activities they would like to see. This collaborative approach ensures that public spaces truly reflect the needs and desires of the residents, fostering a sense of ownership and inclusivity.

These proposed public policy initiatives align with the overarching goal of transforming Indianapolis into a city that prioritizes the well-being, comfort, and connectedness of its residents. By addressing the multifaceted aspects of urban life, from inclusive street furniture to

safety perceptions and community arts, these policies aim to create a holistic and welcoming urban environment for all.

IV. Conclusion

In the pursuit of transforming Indianapolis into a city that is not just habitable but genuinely welcoming and inclusive, our exploration has delved into the intricate dynamics of urban comfort. From the strategic placement of street furniture to the perception of safety and the integration of community arts, each facet contributes to the overarching goal of fostering a sense of belonging and warmth within the city.

1. Inclusive Street Furniture and Amenities:

The introduction of carefully selected and strategically placed street furniture emerges as a foundational element in crafting a welcoming city. Beyond providing functional amenities, these elements become catalysts for social interactions, creating environments that beckon individuals to gather, socialize, and feel a sense of community. The challenge lies not only in inviting people outdoors but in ensuring they feel embraced, at ease, and eager to engage with their surroundings.

2. Safety Perceptions and Inclusivity:

Our exploration extended to the nuanced relationship between urban comfort, safety perceptions, and inclusivity. Findings from the study by J Urban Health shed light on the interconnected factors influencing feelings of safety, emphasizing the importance of addressing not only physical elements like street furniture but also broader socio-cultural aspects. Indianapolis must actively work towards creating an environment where all residents feel secure and embraced, regardless of their background or length of residency.

3. Community Arts as a Catalyst:

Transitioning from the examination of urban comfort dynamics, our focus turned to the transformative role of art in fostering a welcoming and hospitable city. The collaborative research initiative highlighted the power of community arts projects in fostering connections, resilience, and shared expressions. By integrating these projects into the urban fabric, Indianapolis has the potential to cultivate a shared narrative that enhances community pride and unity.

4. Public Policy Proposals for a Holistic Approach:

The proposed public policy initiatives underscore the need for a holistic approach to urban enhancement. From inclusive street furniture to safety measures and community arts, these policies aim to address the multifaceted aspects of urban life. Collaborative efforts with urban planners, community members, and policymakers are essential to ensure the genuine inclusivity and accommodation of diverse needs and preferences.

In conclusion, creating a welcoming city is not a singular endeavor but a collective commitment to shaping a place where residents feel a sense of connection, safety, and pride. By embracing the proposed public policy initiatives, Indianapolis has the opportunity to evolve into a city that prioritizes the well-being, comfort, and connectedness of its residents, setting a benchmark for

welcoming urban environments.

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